

Shame on Silicon Valley



It's the holiday season and most of us are probably out with our families discovering new places or reuniting with friends and relatives at old haunts. One of the best pastimes, especially with children, is to visit museums. I was in Bangalore recently and decided to take my 10-year-old son Aneesh to visit the famed Visveswaraiiah Industrial and Technological Museum in the heart of Bangalore. Named after Sir M. Visveswaraiiah, the brilliant engineer and former dewan of Mysore, the museum was once the central attraction of the city with its amazing array of gadgetry and gizmos. As a student in the early 70s, I had visited the museum several times and among the things that fascinated me was the "room of the future". If you entered the door and clapped, the lights would come on, another clap and music would play and a robotic tray offered you a glass of juice. There were other exhibits which allowed you to discover the joys of science.

Sadly, decades later, the museum is in a sorry state. Most of the 'try me' gadgets housed in the various exhibits were not in working condition. Even if there was an attempt to update it with the latest in technology, these have been done either so poorly or are badly maintained. The room for the future I had seen had given way to an exhibit on the so called wonders of biotechnology. Alas, it was such a clutter of information that there was absolutely no joy in seeing them. The Indian Space Research Organisation had created an enclave for its exhibits but here too maintenance was poor and there has been no attempt to get the latest developments in. My son was soon bored and impatient. And an important occasion to teach him about the wonders of science was lost. In contrast, when I had taken him and my daughter, Aditi, to the Smithsonian Museum in Washington DC last year we spent hours and hours in the museum doing truly extra-ordinary things.

Why should India's science capital and IT hub have such a shabby science and technology museum? Why can't the gurus of our Silicon Valley come together and, in an act of great philanthropy, fund and build one of the finest technological museums in the world for our children to see? Why can't the Science and Technology Ministry spend its money wisely to invest in other cities and boost the quality of science museums across the country? Or, should we presume, nobody really cares.



SEEDHI BAAT ON AAJ TAK

"Some dreams are never accomplished"

ACTOR AND SINGER SHEKHAR SUMAN SPOKE TO EDITOR PRABHU CHAWLA about his acting and his new passion—singing

Q. Why did you turn to singing?

A. I was bored and was getting complacent as an actor. So I decided to accomplish my passion for singing. Singing isn't a career for me.

Q. Many youngsters are also adopting singing as a career. Will you be competition for them?

A. There's no age limit in this profession. If you're passionate to learn, you can do it at any point of your life.

Q. Why is your debut album called Kuch Khwab Aise?

A. Life is a continuation of dreams and a human being begins to build a new dream after he's accomplished one. But some dreams are never accomplished.

Q. Do your dreams get reflected in your songs?

A. Yes. My passions are there. It reflects a definition of love. My songs reflect my expressions of love.

Q. So you're not here for money?

A. No. I am already commercially very successful. Songs come directly from the core of my heart.

Q. Music is a very complex subject.

A. I am not a maestro. I don't want to be a maestro because I cannot be a maestro. If you have an honest voice, it will definitely reach out to people.

Q. Why did you begin with love songs?

A. Because life is another name of love.

Q. How did you start your acting career?

A. I wanted to become an actor. My father is a doctor. I was a stage artist. I got a chance in *Utsav* within a week of coming to Bombay.

Q. Why did you switch to the small screen?

A. Because I lacked acting talent. I signed wrong films. I was a big zero. I had to move to TV to earn my livelihood. I've learnt a lot from failure. I was losing films and then I lost my elder son.

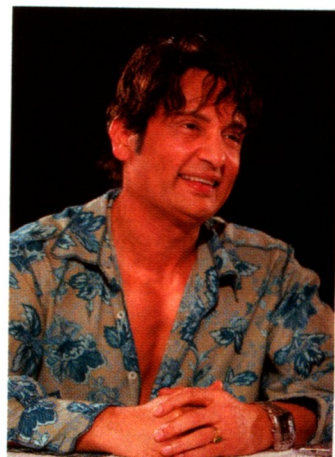
Q. Do you still want to act?

A. Recently Bachchan saheb played the leading man in *Cheeni Kum*. Anupam Kher has played a 70-year-old in *Saransh*. A protagonist can be a young man and an ageing man too. Almost all of our contemporary heroes are over 40.

Q. Which were your best roles?

A. My roles in *Dekh Bhai Dekh* and *Reporter*.

Seedhi Baat is telecast on Aaj Tak at 8.30 p.m. every Sunday and 3.30 p.m. every Monday



MANDAR DEODHAR

Full text of the interview at:

<http://www.indiatoday.com>